

ARGENTINE PAMPAS

One of the richest grazing areas in the world

The term pampas describes the wide, flat, grassy plains of southern South America, covering an area of more than 300,000 sq miles (750,000 sq km). It was named after a Quechua Indian word meaning flat surface. In North America, this sort of habitat is referred to as prairie and in Eurasia as steppe. The dominant vegetation comprises perennial grasses, such as stipas, and herbs.

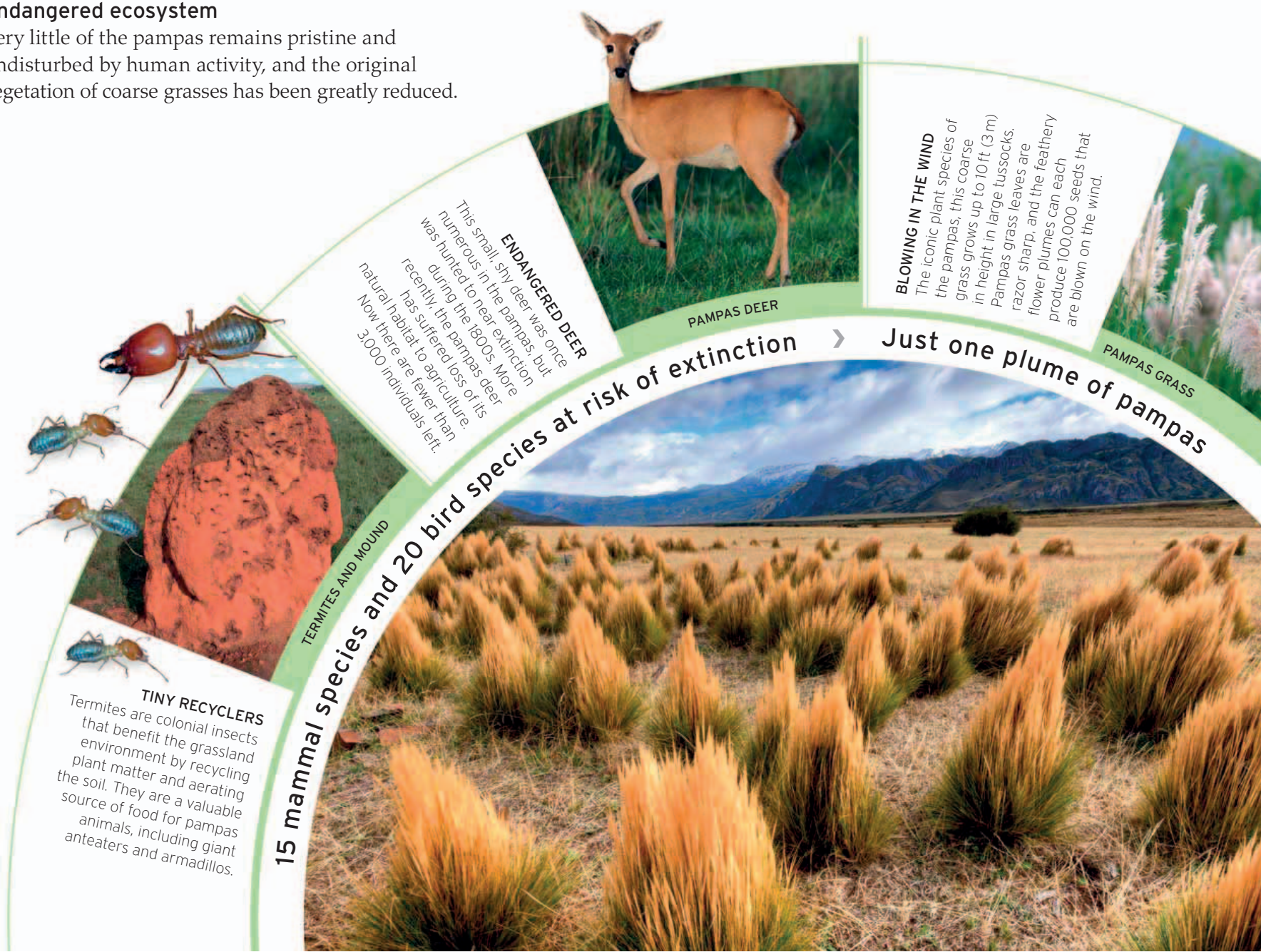
Grasses are able to regenerate after the frequent wildfires, but few trees can survive them and so they are seldom found on the pampas. The scarcity of trees for shade and roosting has led to many animals burrowing underground for shelter.

Endangered ecosystem

Very little of the pampas remains pristine and undisturbed by human activity, and the original vegetation of coarse grasses has been greatly reduced.

Gauchos—cowboys—have herded cows, horses, and sheep on the grasslands for at least 200 years. The temperate climate and rich, fertile soils of the pampas also make it very good for cultivating crops such as soybeans, wheat, maize, and grape vines.

Overgrazing, habitat loss, and fertilizer use has diminished and degraded the natural pampas environment, making it less suitable for its native species. The Argentine pampas ecosystem is classified as an endangered ecoregion by the World Wide Fund for Nature (WWF) because none of the natural pampas is protected, despite plans by the Argentine government to create a national park.



ENDANGERED DEER

This small, shy deer was once numerous in the pampas, but was hunted to near extinction during the 1800s. More recently, the pampas deer has suffered loss of its natural habitat to agriculture. Now there are fewer than 3,000 individuals left.

PAMPAS DEER

BLOWING IN THE WIND

The iconic plant species of the pampas, this coarse grass grows up to 10 ft (3 m) in height in large tussocks. Pampas grass leaves are razor sharp, and the feathery flower plumes can each produce 100,000 seeds that are blown on the wind.

PAMPAS GRASS

Just one plume of pampas

TERMITES AND MOUND

TINY RECYCLERS
Termites are colonial insects that benefit the grassland environment by recycling plant matter and aerating the soil. They are a valuable source of food for pampas animals, including giant anteaters and armadillos.

15 mammal species and 20 bird species at risk of extinction